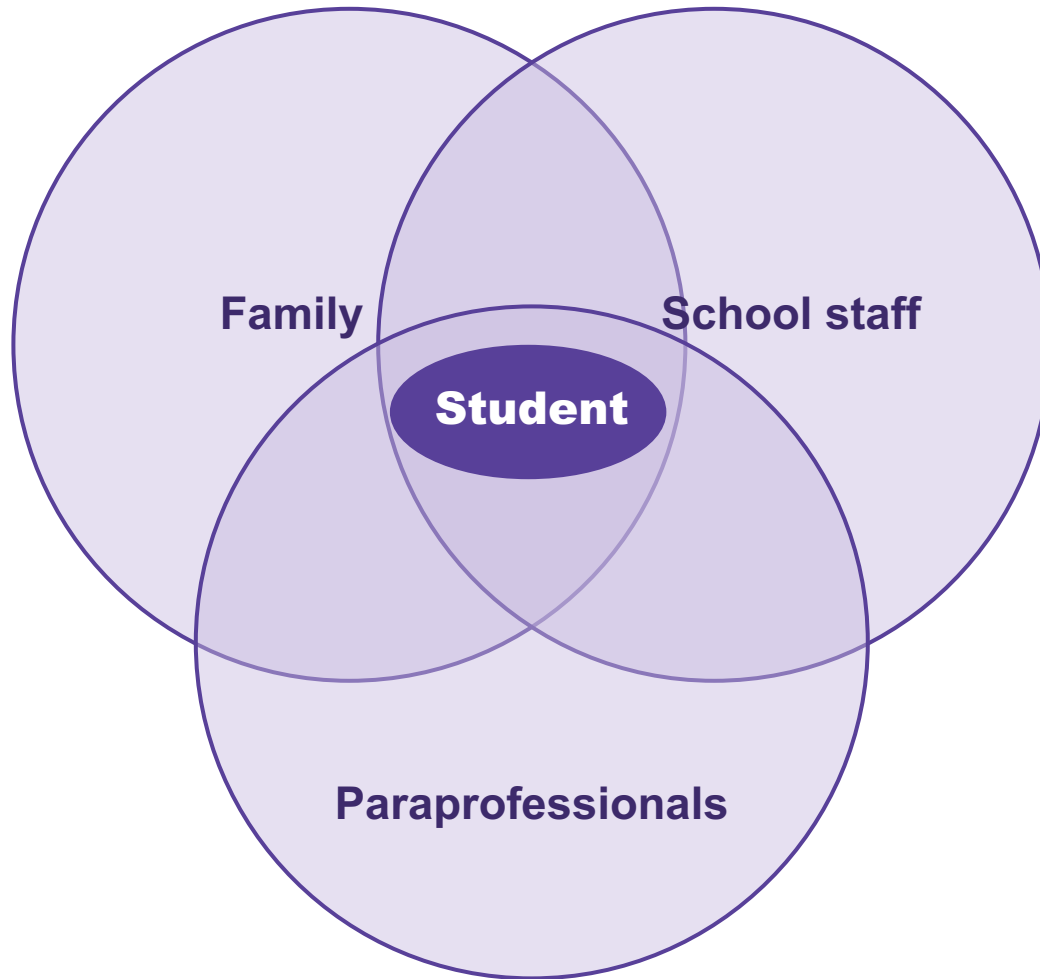




School Leadership · Session 5

# Working in Partnership

# Working in partnership



## What is the goal of these intersecting partnerships?

Every partner brings different knowledge and a different relationship with the student.

**The student is at the centre of every partnership.**

# Building a home-school partnership

**Parents and families are the first and continuing educators of their children**

**Learning is lifelong and occurs in multiple settings**

**Partnerships, schools and school communities flourish when the diversity and strengths of families are valued and leveraged**

**Community engagement expands responsibility and resources**

**Partnerships grow from mutual trust, respect and responsibility**

**Partnerships need committed, collaborative and creative leadership**

Family-School Partnerships Framework, Department of Education, 2020



# What is effective collaboration?

**Shared goals**

**Shared values**

**Mutual trust and respect**

**Consult on decision-making**



**Seeing other perspectives**

**Invite curiosity: How could we work together for better learning outcomes?**

**Centring student voice**

**Assume good intent**

# Family engagement by design

Families should not depend on which teacher they happen to get.

## First contact

Make the first contact each term a positive one.

## Meeting protocols

Shaped with families, so meetings work for them.

## Communication that lasts

Routines that keep going when staff change.

## Access

Interpreters, different meeting formats and flexible times.

**Ask families whether they feel heard, and act on what they tell you.**

# Repairing trust

When a relationship with a family has broken down, leaders can often help reset it.

## Earlier experiences

Many families carry difficult experiences with schools, not just with this teacher.

## Acknowledge

Say what went wrong, without defending the process.

## Listen first

Hear the family before offering solutions.

## Agree a fresh start

A clear next step, who is responsible, and a follow-up date.

Repairing trust with families is part of a leader's role.

# Power dynamics

Power can sit in:

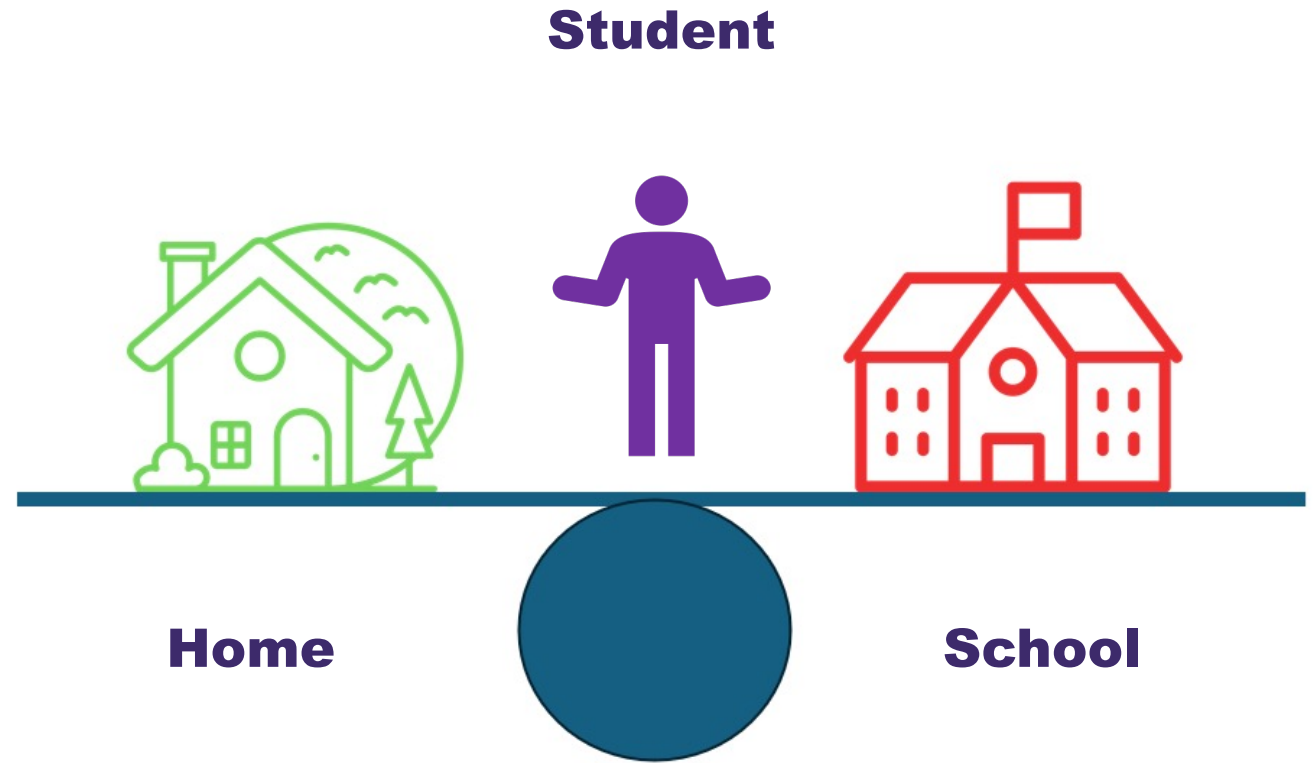
Socio-economic status

Historical / cultural experiences of education

Speaking English vs speaking a language other than English

Pedagogy / understanding of school systems and curriculum

Perception of the importance / experience of school



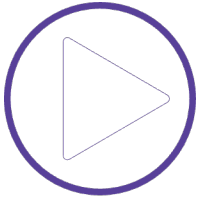
# Power dynamics activity

On Post-it notes:

- 1 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a home perspective.
- 2 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a school perspective.
- 3 Write how you could address these imbalances.

Share at your table, or add your notes to the wall under Home, School and Solutions.

**6 minutes**



## Student voice

**What decisions were made, and who made them?**

**What impact did those decisions have on Adon?**



# Partnership activity

For each partner: what do they bring, and what challenges might they face?

| Student               | Parents and carers    | Teachers              | Paraprofessionals     |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| <div>Brings</div>     | <div>Brings</div>     | <div>Brings</div>     | <div>Brings</div>     |
| <div>Challenges</div> | <div>Challenges</div> | <div>Challenges</div> | <div>Challenges</div> |

8 minutes

Then compare: what do all four have in common?

# What works?



**Think of a family you have a good relationship with.**

How did you establish this? What does it look like? Why does it work?

**What works for everyone at the table:**

**Be prepared for meetings**

**Share information**

**Ask questions**

**Seek clarification**

**Assume the best**

**6 minutes**



# Meeting families where they are

**Listen before solving.**

**Ask about communication preferences and priorities**

**Make room for questions and uncertainty**

**Explain roles, options and next steps plainly**

**Check what is workable for the family now**

**Avoid judging a family's pace, response or choices**

**Environment-first thinking applies to meetings too: what could the school change about the process?**

# Consultation literacy

Useful consultation includes:

**A clear, shared purpose**

**Open questions**

**More than one way to contribute**

**Respect for student and family knowledge**

**Accurate recording of what was heard**

**An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up**

**Ask, listen, and follow up.**

# Consulting students and families

## With students

Offer communication choices

Meeting preparation

Simple choices

Processing time

Sensory-friendly spaces

Behaviour as communication

Strengths and interests

Support - don't speak for

Clear, accessible questions

## With families

Start with students' strengths and interests

Listen to families and value their insights

Use clear, simple language

Respect different perspectives / experiences

Focus on needs, goals and participation

Use real examples from school

Check for shared understanding

Agree on next steps

Keep communication open and ongoing

# When student capacity runs out

**Discuss capacity without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience.**

**Meltdown**

**Shutdown**

**School Can't**

Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change in the environment, task or response.

# Partnership tools

## Working Together Communication Tool

| How are we going to communicate as a home school partnership?<br><small>(Circle or highlight the ones that are most useful to you)</small> | How often are we going to communicate this way and what are we going to communicate about? | Next steps and dates<br><small>(write in any meetings or planned communication and when they will happen)</small> |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  Text                                                     |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  Email                                                    |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  App                                                      |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  Phone                                                    |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  Communication book                                      |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  Face to face                                           |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |
|  Other                                                  |                                                                                            |                                                                                                                   |

## Partnership Planning Template

- This template may help parents/carers and school staff to work together. You can tick a box or write down extra ideas.
- The first column lists what has worked well.
- The second column lists what has been challenging.
- The third column lists what could help.

| What has worked for you?                                                             | What has been challenging?                                                     | What could help?                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Regular face-to-face catch-ups                              | <input type="checkbox"/> Ongoing written communication between home and school | <input type="checkbox"/> Having a regular time to meet                         |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Regular written feedback, i.e. communication book, reports. | <input type="checkbox"/> Sharing of goals and concerns                         | <input type="checkbox"/> Ongoing written communication between home and school |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Regular text messages                                       | <input type="checkbox"/> Finding a time for parents and schools to speak       | <input type="checkbox"/> Having an advocate or support person at the meetings  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Regular emails                                              | <input type="checkbox"/> Understanding what is important to talk about         | <input type="checkbox"/> Sharing how things are going at home or at school     |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Regular video conferencing                                  | <input type="checkbox"/> Feeling heard                                         | <input type="checkbox"/> Sharing key things that may impact on home or school  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Recorded meetings, i.e. audio, video.                       | <input type="checkbox"/> Communication, i.e. expressing myself                 | <input type="checkbox"/> Voice of the young person being included              |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Meetings with an advocate                                   | <input type="checkbox"/> Listening for extended periods of time                | <input type="checkbox"/> List of goals                                         |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Group meetings with an advocate                             | <input type="checkbox"/> Environment, i.e. fluorescent lighting, noise levels  | <input type="checkbox"/> Different meeting environment                         |
| <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                       | <input type="checkbox"/> Negative experiences in the past                      | <input type="checkbox"/> Visual support for ideas shared in meetings           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                       | <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                 | <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                 |
| <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                       | <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                 | <input type="checkbox"/> _____                                                 |

# NCCD Meetings Tool Kit

Use the toolkit to make the meeting purpose, consultation process, possible adjustments, evidence and next steps clear. Follow the processes used in your school or system, and explain responsibilities and follow-up.

<https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>



The screenshot shows the NCCD website interface. At the top, there's a dark header with 'Disability Standards for Education resources', 'Frequently asked questions', 'My bookmarks', 'Register', and 'Sign in'. Below this is a light blue navigation bar with the NCCD logo, 'An Australian Government Initiative', a search bar, and a menu with options: 'Understanding the NCCD', 'NCCD Phases', 'Resources and tools', 'Professional learning', and 'Help and support'. The main content area is titled 'Meetings toolkit' and includes a brief introduction about federal law and the purpose of the toolkit. A list of links is provided for further exploration.

Disability Standards for Education resources | Frequently asked questions | My bookmarks | Register | Sign in

**NCCD** | An Australian Government Initiative

Understanding the NCCD | NCCD Phases | Resources and tools | Professional learning | Help and support

Resources and tools / Wider support materials / Meetings toolkit

Was this resource helpful to you? 203

## Meetings toolkit

Federal law states that students with disability have the right to be consulted before the education provider makes adjustments to enable them to participate in education on the same basis as students without disability. Anyone in a personal or professional relationship with the student can ask for a meeting and everyone should know the purpose of the meeting and who will attend. Talking through the issues and using an agenda can assist people to make decisions about the student's needs.

### The toolkit

This toolkit contains tips for people who have to organise or attend a meeting.

- > [Requesting a meeting](#)
- > [Managing meetings](#)
- > [Being prepared](#)
- > [Managing emotions](#)
- > [Keeping records](#)
- > [Was the meeting successful?](#)

## Other practical supports

# Autism Connect

## National autism helpline



Emotional, practical and  
financial support for carers.  
Call 1800 422 737.

# Bridge to the next family conversation



## **Prepare for one purposeful conversation.**

- What needs to be understood?
- What question will open the conversation?
- How will the student's voice be included?
- What can be decided together?
- How and when will the school follow up?

**Keep these notes for your conversation plan in Session 6.**